

REUTERS/ADIL KHAN



Fazlullah's TTP is only loosely allied with the similarly-named organisation of Pakistan's most wanted militant Baitullah Mehsud, operating out of Waziristan Agency in FATA but the US in particular was wary of Al Qaida finding another foothold in Pakistan. There was also evidence that militant jihadi organisations from Punjab and elsewhere were beginning to use the area as a sanctuary. Faqir Mohammad, the militant driven out of Bajaur, for example, is now said to be in Swat along with his fighters. Reports

Congress about Pakistan's commitment in the fight against militancy. President Obama's administration was able to push through large aid packages through the Congress without much difficulty, helped along by sympathetic testimony from Secretary of State Hillary Clinton and Special Envoy Richard Holbrooke. Holbrooke, in fact, claimed Zardari had predicted the collapse of the Swat accord even at the time he had given his assent to it. Under the new package, the US has committed to providing \$1.5 billion a year to Pakistan for

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(FAR LEFT) REFUGEES STREAM OUT OF BUNER; (LEFT) OBAMA WITH KARZAI AND ZARDARI

WITH 1.5 MILLION PEOPLE MADE REFUGEES, PAKISTAN NOW HAS THE LARGEST NUMBER OF INTERNALLY DISPLACED PEOPLE IN THE WORLD.

tion of limiting themselves to Swat. Telephone intercepts between Fazlullah and his commanders seem to have convinced the army's brass that the TTP was not serious about the accords and that Sufi's influence was extremely limited.

Pressure had also been building against the Government from civil society within Pakistan which saw the accord as a "capitulation by the Pakistani state to terrorists and militants"—as some commentators in the media dubbed it—as well as from western governments alarmed over the creation of another "safe haven" for militancy.

coming out of Buner, where Taliban militants attacked local communities who were resisting them and blew up the tomb of a Sufi saint, further incensed public opinion. It was this pressure, which became particularly pronounced as President Zardari prepared to go to the US to meet President Barack Obama, which forced Prime Minister Yousuf Raza Gilani to announce a "decisive" military action against the Malakand militants on May 7.

Meanwhile, the decision to announce the military operation may certainly have made it easier for Zardari to convince an increasingly sceptical US

the next five years and is also providing emergency assistance for IDPs in the light of the "critical" battle for Swat.

Awami National Party insiders—who had championed the accords the most—are now falling over themselves to claim to the media, in conspiratorial tones, that the push for the accords was all part of a grand strategy to "expose" the militants' real agenda. But few are buying their explanations. Major-General Athar Abbas, head of the military's Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), is a bit more forthright while defending the accords. "We faced a major problem the last time we went in," he says. "We could not identify who the militants were and when we did, the local population would block us from acting against them. We had to find a way to ideologically isolate the militants from the civilians who simply wanted cheap and quick justice and who had begun to support the Taliban because they felt they could provide that. The